Research Scholar

The Research Scholar role is a one-year visiting position. It is designed to support the career development of AI governance researchers and practitioners, while offering opportunities to do impactful work.

As a Research Scholar, you will have freedom to pursue many different projects. This could include conducting policy research, social science research, or technical research; advising policymakers; or starting new applied projects.

For example, past scholars have used the position to help define the field of technical AI governance, inform frontier AI company safety frameworks, support policymaking through government secondments, and launch a new organisation to build safety evaluations and RL environments for frontier AI companies.

The topics we work on include, but are not limited to: risk management, threat modeling, economics of AI, geopolitics of AI, public policy, and technical governance.

Over the course of the year, you will deepen your understanding of the field, connect with a network of experts, and build your skills and professional profile – within an institutional home that offers both flexibility and support.

Applications for the Research Scholar position are open. The deadline for applications is 23:59 Anywhere on Earth (AoE) on Sunday, 16 August 2026.

Opportunities | July 20, 2026

About the Team

GovAI was founded to help humanity navigate the transition to a world with advanced AI. Our researchers have provided knowledge and assistance to decision makers in government, industry, and civil society. Our alumni have gone on to influential roles in government (US, UK, EU); leading AI companies, including Google DeepMind, OpenAI, and Anthropic; think-tanks such as the Center for Strategic and International Studies, Center for Security and Emerging Technology, Center for a New American Security and the Tony Blair Institute; and to leadership roles on initiatives like the International AI Safety Report. Our initial research agenda, published in 2018, helped define and shape the nascent field of AI governance. We made significant early contributions to the ongoing public discussions over the security implications of AI. More recently, we have made significant contributions to EU AI policy, with staff members vice-chairing the EU AI Act GPAI Code of Practice risk-management working group and sitting on the EU AI Office Scientific Panel & Advisory Forum.

Our researchers have published in leading journals and conferences, including Science, Nature, NeurIPS, FAccT and ICML. We have published commentary in venues such as TIME, Foreign Affairs, War on the Rocks, and Lawfare. Our work has also been covered by publications such as The New York Times, Vox, and the Financial Times.

Our staff are based across the United Kingdom, United States, and European Union.

About the Role

The Research Scholar role is designed to support your career development in AI governance, with significant flexibility to pursue this goal as you see fit.

You will be supervised by a member of the GovAI team or network (typically meeting weekly), be mentored by an external expert or another GovAI team member, receive guidance and support from one of our Research Managers, and get feedback from our team through regular work-in-progress sessions.

Your Research Scholar year may involve:

- Informing policymakers and decision-makers on pressing governance issues
- Producing original research in the form of academic publications, policy memos, reports, or blog posts
- Convening key stakeholders around high-priority questions
- Launching a new initiative or organisation
- Helping assess prospective new hires for our seasonal fellowship and scholar/fellow roles

Note: For researchers with significant experience in AI governance research, we are also hiring **Research Fellows**. These are longer-term staff roles with two-year renewable contracts that focus on contributing to core research workstreams. There is a shared application for both Research Scholar and Research Fellow roles, so you need only submit one application.

Areas of Interest

Our researchers work on a broad range of topics related to AI governance. While much of our work concerns general-purpose AI systems, we're also interested in research on narrower AI applications and their policy implications. Our research spans several areas, including:

- **Risk Management:** How can AI companies make responsible development and deployment decisions, successfully managing risks without hindering innovation and adoption? What is the role of third parties – evaluators and auditors – in informing such decisions?
- **Threat Modeling:** What is the state of evidence regarding different hypothesized risks from AI and what further information would be most useful for reducing uncertainty? At the same time, what role can AI progress and adoption play in mitigating risks?
- **Economics of AI:** What will the economic implications of AI development and deployment be? How might it affect labour markets, competition, and growth?
- **Geopolitics of AI:** What strategies are different states using to compete in AI and how effective will they be? How do geopolitical dynamics shape AI development and governance?
- **Frontier AI regulation:** What effects will different regulatory proposals have on frontier AI? In what ways will existing regulation need to be amended or removed in light of AI developments?
- **Technical Governance:** What technical work could help address challenges in AI governance? To what extent is compute an important tool? How can evaluations keep pace with AI progress?

We are also interested in researchers pursuing other topics, including the implications of AI R&D automation, the use of AI by governments, increasing society's resilience in anticipation of advances in AI, and how society can capture AI benefits.

Some of our most impactful Research Scholars have dedicated the majority of their time to applied work, rather than traditional research. **We also welcome applications from candidates who would primarily focus on launching new AI governance organizations, organizing high-impact events, educating policymakers on AI, or supporting other applied work**.

Qualifications and Selection Criteria

We are open to candidates with diverse academic and professional backgrounds. We have previously hired researchers with backgrounds in computer science, political science, public policy, economics, history, philosophy, and law, as well as professionals from government, industry, and civil society. **There are no educational requirements for this role.**

Essential Qualifications

Successful candidates will have:

- A strong interest in positively shaping the lasting impacts of AI, in line with our mission
- Demonstrated ability to produce excellent work or achieve impressive results
- Some familiarity with AI governance
- Some expertise in a domain that is relevant to AI governance
- A compelling explanation of how this position will help you have a large impact

What We Value

They will also likely demonstrate:

- Self-direction and the ability to evaluate projects based on impact
- Intellectual honesty and rigor
- Receptiveness to feedback and commitment to self-improvement
- Strong communication and collaboration skills
- Motivation to help others succeed

Additional Considerations

For candidates who are hoping to do specific kinds of work (e.g. technical research) or work on particular topics (e.g. US policy), we will also look for expertise and experience in those particular areas.

The most promising candidates typically have either graduate degrees or relevant professional experience, but we consider applicants at all career stages and have hired talented scholars with less experience.

Duration, Location, and Salary

Duration

Contracts will be for a fixed 12-month term. While these contracts are non-renewable, Research Scholars may apply for longer-term positions at GovAI — such as Research Fellow positions — at the end of their contract.

Location

We typically prefer candidates to be based in London, UK or Washington, DC, but are open to candidates based elsewhere (e.g. the Bay Area).

We do have stronger location preferences in some cases:

- **Policy-focused work:** If you plan to focus heavily on a particular government's policies, we prefer you to be based in or near the relevant city (e.g. Washington DC for US federal policy).
- **Project management roles:** If you'll be managing projects or launching new initiatives, we prefer you work out of one of our offices.
- **Supervisor preferences:** Some supervisors prefer their supervisees to be based in the same office as them.

If you have location restrictions that might prevent you from applying, please inquire at recruitment@governance.ai.

We are able to sponsor visas in the UK. We can only support visa sponsorship in exceptional cases in the US, and in many instances, will not be able to support a visa petition. If location constraints might affect your ability to apply, please contact recruitment@governance.ai.

Salary

Compensation is based on experience and location. Successful candidates based in London typically receive between **£75,000 and £103,500** per year, and those based in Washington, DC typically earn **$100,000–$165,000**.

We offer additional compensation for candidates in higher cost-of-living regions, such as the San Francisco Bay Area. There may be additional flexibility in compensation in cases where salary considerations would prevent a candidate from accepting an offer.

Other benefits of the role include:

- Health, dental, and vision insurance
- A £5,000 annual wellbeing budget (a salary uplift in lieu of this budget for US-based staff)
- A £5,000 (~$6,500) annual professional development budget
- A £5,000 (~$6,500) annual childcare budget
- Remote staff get a £4,500 (~$6,000) annual coworking space budget
- Flexible work hours
- Extended parental leave
- Ergonomic equipment
- A 10% employer pension contribution
- 33 days of paid vacation (including public holidays)

Please contact recruitment@governance.ai if you have questions or concerns regarding compensation or benefits that might affect your decision to apply.

How to Apply and What to Expect

Application Process

The selection process has four stages:

1. Written application
2. An abstract reasoning assessment
3. 1-2 paid remote work tests
    1. Candidates who reach this stage for the ***Research Fellow*** track may also be asked to produce a detailed research agenda outlining how they would approach their first two years at GovAI
    2. Some workstreams will require a second paid work test
4. Two interviews and reference checks

Special Circumstances

Please contact recruitment@governance.ai if you:

- Need a decision communicated by a particular date
- Require assistance with the application due to a disability
- Have questions about the application process

Addressing complex AI governance challenges requires many different skillsets and perspectives. We welcome applicants from a wide range of backgrounds. If our mission excites you, we encourage you to apply, even if your experience doesn't align perfectly with every qualification listed. Your unique combination of experience and motivation might be exactly what we're looking for.

Apply

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